

D837

Secondary Social Studies Curriculum

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

Congress passes a transportation bill after months of hearings in a newly remodeled committee room. The President vetoes it. Congress then votes again, and the bill passes with two-thirds support in both the House and Senate. Which check did Congress use in the second vote?

- A. A veto override.
- B. A simple majority vote that ends all presidential power over laws.
- C. Judicial review.
- D. Impeachment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which action is the judicial branch's check on Congress?

- A. Declaring a law unconstitutional.
- B. Vetoing a bill.
- C. Writing new laws to replace unwanted ones.
- D. Confirming judges.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A state that has grown rapidly and has several large universities sets its own rules for issuing driver's licenses. Its governor was recently reelected. What gives the state this power?

- A. The governor's reelection.
- B. The Supremacy Clause.
- C. Enumerated powers of Congress.
- D. Reserved powers under the Tenth Amendment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A valid federal law and a state law directly conflict. Which law generally controls, and why?

- A.** Both laws always apply equally.
- B.** Whichever law was passed more recently.
- C.** The federal law, because of the Supremacy Clause.
- D.** The state law, because of the Tenth Amendment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

In one hour, Country A can produce 12 tons of wheat or 6 bolts of cloth. Country B can produce 4 tons of wheat or 4 bolts of cloth. Country A has a larger population and a warmer climate. Which country has the comparative advantage in cloth?

- A.** Country A, because of its larger population.
- B.** Country A, because its opportunity cost of cloth is 0.5 wheat.
- C.** Country B, because its opportunity cost of cloth is 1 wheat compared with 2 wheat for A.
- D.** Country A, because it produces more cloth per hour.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Using the same data (A: 12 wheat or 6 cloth; B: 4 wheat or 4 cloth), what is Country A's opportunity cost of producing one ton of wheat?

- A.** 0.5 bolt of cloth.
- B.** 1 bolt of cloth.
- C.** 2 bolts of cloth.
- D.** 12 tons of wheat.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

During a slowdown, the Federal Reserve, whose chair gave a widely watched speech, lowers its target interest rate and buys government bonds. Unemployment had risen to 6%. What kind of policy is this?

- A.** Trade policy.
- B.** Expansionary monetary policy.
- C.** Expansionary fiscal policy.
- D.** Contractionary monetary policy.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Congress cuts income taxes and increases spending on highways to fight a recession. What kind of policy is this?

- A.** Contractionary fiscal policy.
- B.** Supply-side deregulation.
- C.** Expansionary fiscal policy.
- D.** Expansionary monetary policy.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A student looking at a Mercator wall map that hangs above the classroom’s new smart board says Greenland looks about as big as Africa. The map was printed last year. What should the teacher explain?

- A.** Mercator shrinks areas near the poles.
- B.** The sizes are accurate because the map is new.
- C.** Every map shows area accurately.
- D.** The Mercator projection enlarges areas near the poles; Africa is actually about 14 times larger than Greenland.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

In the 1840s, a crop disease caused mass hunger in a country, and many families left for a nation known to offer factory jobs. The ships took several weeks, and many families traveled with their cousins. Which is a push factor in this case?

- A.** Factory jobs in the new nation.
- B.** The famine caused by crop disease.
- C.** The weeks-long ship journey.
- D.** Traveling with cousins.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A teacher who has visited many Civil War battlefields asks: Which amendment requires states to give all persons equal protection of the laws? The question is part of a new review packet. What is the answer?

- A.** The 1st Amendment.
- B.** The 13th Amendment.
- C.** The 15th Amendment.
- D.** The 14th Amendment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A researcher studies how the structure of schools and families in a large city affects rates of college enrollment across neighborhoods. The research is funded by a well-known foundation. Which social science best fits this study?

- A.** Economics, because it is funded by a foundation.
- B.** Sociology.
- C.** Psychology.
- D.** Anthropology.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

Congress passes a transportation bill ~~after months of hearings in a newly remodeled committee room~~. The President vetoes it. Congress then votes again, and the bill passes with two-thirds support in both the House and Senate. Which check did Congress use in the second vote?

Target word: name the check **Decides:** A two-thirds vote in both houses after a veto.

A	Correct	Two-thirds of both houses can override a presidential veto.
B	Absolute language	An override needs two-thirds, and it does not end the veto power.
C	Confusion set	That is the courts' power, not Congress's.
D	Adjacent category	Removes officials; it does not pass bills.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

Which action is the judicial branch's check on Congress?

Target word: reverse: check from the courts **Decides:** Courts rule on constitutionality.

A	Correct	Judicial review, established in Marbury v. Madison.
B	Confusion set	The President's check.
C	Adjacent category	Lawmaking belongs to Congress.
D	Inverted operation	The Senate's check on the courts, the reverse direction.

3. Answer D Concept 2

A state ~~that has grown rapidly and has several large universities~~ sets its own rules for issuing driver's licenses. ~~Its governor was recently reelected.~~ What gives the state this power?

Target word: source of state power **Decides:** Licensing drivers is not delegated to the national government.

A	Camouflage	Elections do not create constitutional powers.
B	Inverted operation	That makes federal law supreme, the opposite direction.
C	Confusion set	Those belong to the national government.
D	Correct	Powers not given to the national government are reserved to the states.

4. Answer C Concept 2 • transfer

A valid federal law and a state law directly conflict. Which law generally controls, and why?

Target word: resolve a conflict **Decides:** Supremacy Clause.

A	Absolute language	A direct conflict cannot be resolved by applying both.
B	Adjacent category	Timing does not decide federal-state conflicts.
C	Correct	Valid federal law overrides conflicting state law.
D	Inverted operation	Reserved powers do not override valid federal law.

5. Answer C Concept 3

In one hour, Country A can produce 12 tons of wheat or 6 bolts of cloth. Country B can produce 4 tons of wheat or 4 bolts of cloth. ~~Country A has a larger population and a warmer climate.~~ Which country has the comparative advantage in cloth?

Target word: comparative advantage in cloth **Decides:** Opportunity cost of 1 cloth: A gives up 2 wheat, B gives up 1 wheat.

A	Camouflage	Population is irrelevant to opportunity cost.
B	Inverted operation	0.5 is A's cost of wheat in cloth, not of cloth in wheat.
C	Correct	The lower opportunity cost decides comparative advantage.
D	Confusion set	That is absolute advantage.

6. Answer A Concept 3 • transfer

Using the same data (A: 12 wheat or 6 cloth; B: 4 wheat or 4 cloth), what is Country A's opportunity cost of producing one ton of wheat?

Target word: solve for the other good's cost **Decides:** 6 cloth / 12 wheat.

A	Correct	$6 / 12 = 0.5$ cloth per ton of wheat.
B	Confusion set	That is Country B's cost.
C	Inverted operation	That is $12 / 6$, A's cost of cloth in wheat.
D	Wrong stem number	A stem number, not an opportunity cost.

7. Answer B Concept 4

During a slowdown, the Federal Reserve, ~~whose chair gave a widely watched speech,~~ lowers its target interest rate and buys government bonds. ~~Unemployment had risen to 6%.~~ What kind of policy is this?

Target word: type of policy **Decides:** The Fed acts through rates and bond purchases.

A	Adjacent category	Tariffs and trade deals are different tools.
B	Correct	The Fed increasing money supply and lowering rates.
C	Confusion set	Fiscal policy is taxing and spending by Congress.
D	Inverted operation	Lowering rates expands, not contracts.

8. Answer C Concept 4 • transfer

Congress cuts income taxes and increases spending on highways to fight a recession. What kind of policy is this?

Target word: reverse: taxing and spending **Decides:** Congress uses taxes and spending.

A	Inverted operation	Cutting taxes and raising spending expands.
B	Adjacent category	No regulation was changed.
C	Correct	Lower taxes and more spending boost demand.
D	Confusion set	Monetary policy belongs to the Fed.

9. Answer D Concept 5

A student looking at a Mercator wall map ~~that hangs above the classroom's new smart board~~ says Greenland looks about as big as Africa. ~~The map was printed last year.~~ What should the teacher explain?

Target word: projection distortion **Decides:** Mercator enlarges areas near the poles.

A	Inverted operation	It enlarges them.
B	Camouflage	Print date does not remove projection distortion.
C	Absolute language	All flat maps distort something.
D	Correct	Area distortion grows with latitude.

10. Answer B Concept 6

In the 1840s, a crop disease caused mass hunger in a country, and many families left for a nation known to offer factory jobs. ~~The ships took several weeks, and many families traveled with their cousins.~~ Which is a push factor in this case?

Target word: classify the factor **Decides:** Famine at the origin drives people out.

A	Inverted operation	A pull factor at the destination.
B	Correct	Conditions at the origin that drive people away.
C	Camouflage	An obstacle, not a push factor.
D	Adjacent category	Family ties at the destination would be a pull; travel companions are neither.

11. Answer D Concept 7

A teacher ~~who has visited many Civil War battlefields~~ asks: Which amendment requires states to give all persons equal protection of the laws? ~~The question is part of a new review packet.~~ What is the answer?

Target word: which amendment **Decides:** Equal protection is in the 14th.

A	Adjacent category	Freedoms of speech, religion, press, assembly, and petition.
B	Confusion set	Abolished slavery.
C	Confusion set	Protects voting regardless of race.
D	Correct	Citizenship, due process, and equal protection.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A researcher studies how the structure of schools and families in a large city affects rates of college enrollment across neighborhoods. ~~The research is funded by a well-known foundation.~~ Which social science best fits this study?

Target word: match the discipline **Decides:** Institutions and group patterns within a society.

A	Camouflage	Funding source does not decide the discipline.
B	Correct	Studies institutions and group patterns.
C	Confusion set	Focuses on individual mind and behavior.
D	Adjacent category	Studies whole cultures, often through fieldwork.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	0	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	9	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	10	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	5	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Checks and balances	Each branch can limit the others: presidential veto, congressional override (two-thirds of both houses), Senate confirmation, and judicial review.	Confusing separation of powers (who does what) with checks (how one branch limits another).	One branch acts on another branch's decision.
2	Federalism: reserved powers and supremacy	Powers not delegated to the national government are reserved to the states (Tenth Amendment); valid federal law overrides conflicting state law (Supremacy Clause).	Assuming the national government controls everything, or that states can ignore federal law.	A power held by a state or a conflict between state and federal law.
3	Comparative advantage	Specialize in the good with the lower opportunity cost, even if another producer is better at both.	Deciding by absolute advantage (who produces more).	Two producers, two goods, output per hour.
4	Fiscal vs. monetary policy	Fiscal policy is taxing and spending by Congress and the President; monetary policy is money supply and interest rates by the Federal Reserve.	Crediting the Federal Reserve with tax cuts or Congress with interest-rate changes.	Who acts and what tool they use.
5	Map projections distort	Every flat map distorts something; the Mercator projection keeps direction and shape locally but greatly enlarges areas near the poles.	Reading sizes directly off a Mercator map.	High-latitude land looks unusually large.
6	Push and pull factors	Push factors drive people out of a place (war, famine, persecution); pull factors draw them to a place (jobs, freedom, family).	Labeling a factor by whether it is good or bad rather than by which place it describes.	A reason for migration tied to the origin or the destination.
7	The Reconstruction Amendments	The 13th Amendment abolished slavery; the 14th defined citizenship and guaranteed equal protection and due process; the 15th barred denying the vote based on race.	Mixing up which amendment did what.	Citizenship, equal protection, or voting rights after the Civil War.
8	The social sciences by level of analysis	Psychology studies individual behavior and mind; sociology studies groups and institutions in societies; anthropology studies human cultures, often through fieldwork and comparison.	Treating sociology and psychology as interchangeable.	Whether the question focuses on an individual, a society's institutions, or a culture as a whole.

Course scope (public description): Secondary Social Studies Curriculum explores the key concepts of U.S. history, world history, economics, government, geography, and social sciences. Designed for aspiring social studies educators, this course will refresh and deepen candidates' understanding of the material they will teach in secondary classrooms and prepare them for the Praxis Social Studies (5081) exam. Candidates in this course will

learn to compare historical concepts and resources as they develop the best materials for their classrooms.